

Now check the file `sample2.php` against your new sniffer:

```
$phpcs --standards=PROJECT_A /var/www/sample2.php
```

```
FILE: /var/www/sample2.php
```

```
-----
FOUND 1 ERROR(S) AFFECTING 1 LINE(S)
-----
```

```
5 | ERROR | Test code exist .Pls Remove it. found curl_
setopt
-----
```

On deployment, the above error will warn the developer to remove the temporary lines.

Using a code sniffer with an editor

In the above example, we have used the PHPCS as a standalone tool. We then have to edit and save the code by using an editor to check the coding standards in the command line. To make our lives easier, there are some editors that provide the option to integrate the PHPCS by using a plugin.

A pretty famous and much-used editor among open source developers is the *Vim* editor. Let's integrate PHPCS with *Vim*. The plugin that integrates PHPCS with *Vim* is *vim-phpqa* (<https://github.com/joonty/vim-phpqa>). A simple way to install this plugin with *Vim* is to use the *Vundle* plugin manager. Given below are the steps to help you install *Vim*, *Vundle* and the *vim-phpqa* plugin.

To install *Vim* (in Ubuntu/Debian Linux), type the following command:

```
#apt-get install vim
```

To install *Vundle*, type:

```
$ mkdir ~/.vim/bundle
$ git clone https://github.com/gmarik/vundle.git ~/.vim/
bundle/vundle
```

To install the plugin globally, add the following lines to the file `/etc/vim/vimrc.local`:

```
set rtp+=~/.vim/bundle/vundle/
call vundle#rc()
```

```
" To manage Vundle by Vundle
Bundle 'gmarik/vundle'
```

```
"For php-qa plugin
Bundle 'joonty/vim-phpqa.git'
```

```
" PHP executable (default = "php")
let g:phpqa_php_cmd="/path/to/php"
```

```
" " PHP Code Sniffer binary (default = "phpcs")
let g:phpqa_codesniffer_cmd="/home/bala/Downloads/PHPCS/
PHPCS/scripts/phpcs"
```

```
" Set the codesniffer args
let g:phpqa_codesniffer_args = "--standard=PEAR"
```

To install the plug-in, run the following command in the terminal:

```
vim +BundleInstall +qall
```

Editing PHP files by using *Vim*

Now create any PHP code by using the *Vim* editor. If you want to check the coding standards, save the code and it will automatically call the PHPCS to check the coding standards.

If you don't want to call it automatically, you can set it off by using the following configuration on the `vimrc.local` file:

```
let g:phpqa_codesniffer_autorun = 0
```

To run it on demand, use the command *Phpcs*.

Vim shows the report in a separate tab. You can switch to the report tab by using `Ctrl + w`. Navigate the report and select the error. This will take you to the corresponding line in the code.

A code beautifier vs a code sniffer

There are some who would argue that a developer should use the code beautifier instead of the code sniffer. What is the difference between the two?

Code beautifiers format the code automatically, which reduces work considerably, but what happens if the code has bugs and introduces syntax errors in the program? It may lead to the Web application crashing.

A code sniffer checks the code and produces the list of flaws as a report. It forces the programmer to check the code. It does not alter anything on its own. It does not do the programmer's job. It adds to the responsibilities of programmers and actually makes them code perfectly.

So, if you want to understand existing dirty code that runs into hundreds of lines, you can use a code beautifier. But if you want to follow the coding standards, individually or as a team member on your project, a code sniffer is the right tool for you. 

References

- http://pear.php.net/package/PHP_CodeSniffer/docs
- <https://github.com/joonty/vim-phpqa>

By: Bala Vignesh Kashinathan

The author has over nine years of experience in Web applications development with open source technologies. Apart from the technical stuff, he spends most of his time with his baby, Kavibharathi. Contact him at: kbalavignesh@gmail.com or balaivignesh.kasinathan@cgci.com